

Paper 3: Written Coursework

The coursework option is open to centres that have been approved by Edexcel to conduct coursework. There are two papers — **Paper 3 must be taken with Paper 4.**

Coursework is available (Edexcel approved teaching institutions only) as an alternative to Paper 2.

Content overview

Students have to complete two assignments — one on reading and one on writing.

Reading

A piece of writing responding to Section B of the *Edexcel Anthology for International GCSE and Certificate Qualifications in English Language and Literature*.

All students will be required to demonstrate an ability to:

AO2

- (i) read and understand texts with insight and engagement
- (iii) understand and make some evaluation of how writers use linguistic and structural devices to achieve their effects.

Writing

A piece of personal and imaginative writing to explore, imagine, entertain and writing to argue, persuade, advise.

All students will be required to demonstrate an ability to:

AO3

- (i) communicate clearly and appropriately, using and adapting forms for different readers and purposes
- (ii) organise ideas into sentences, paragraphs and whole texts using a variety of linguistic and structural features
- (iii) use a range of sentence structures effectively, with accurate punctuation and spelling.

Assessment overview

- The assessment of this unit is through two coursework assignments, internally set and assessed and externally moderated by Edexcel.
- The total number of marks available is 80 (40 marks for each assignment).

Detailed content

Paper 3, for students taking route two (70% assessment and 30% coursework), assesses 20% of the total English Language (Specification A) qualification and assesses Reading (10%) and Writing (10%).

Students will complete **two** coursework assignments.

Assignment 1

- Writing based on a piece or pieces from Section B of the anthology.
- This assignment must address AO2 (i) and (iii).
- Marked out of 40 marks for reading.

Assignment 2

- A piece of personal and imaginative writing.
- The assignment may encompass a wide range of possible types of writing including autobiographical, creative, descriptive and discursive.
- Its purpose should be to explore, imagine, entertain **or** to argue, persuade, advise.
- Within the boundaries stated above there is a free choice of topic.
- This assignment must address AO3 (i), (ii) and (iii).
- Marked out of 40 marks for writing.

Production of written coursework

Each piece of coursework should contain the student's name, the date on which the work was completed, the mark awarded and a brief teacher comment justifying the mark. This comment should be based on the assessment criteria for the mark range awarded.

There is no minimum or maximum word limit for coursework pieces. Typically, a coursework piece might be 450 to 600 words, but there is no penalty for exceeding these guidelines. A piece of descriptive writing for assignment 2, for example, may be fewer than 450 words. A story for the same assignment may be well over 1,000 words. The length of the piece should be determined by 'fitness for purpose'.

Coursework pieces may be handwritten or word-processed.

Teachers may advise students in the production of coursework, but they should **not** proofread early drafts and correct every technical error. Teachers may suggest improvements to the content of the coursework, but it is the student's responsibility to make any corrections. There is no limit to the number of coursework pieces a student may produce from which to select the best pieces for final assessment, nor to the number of drafts a student may produce. However, teachers should be mindful of the overall weighting of written coursework (20%) and make sure that the coursework paper does not take up an inordinate amount of curriculum time.

Teachers should be alert to essays derived from other sources — such as the internet — when signing the declaration on the coursework front sheet.

Examples of assignments

Reading

This teacher-devised assignment could be a detailed analysis of the language of one piece from Section B of the anthology, or a comparative piece based on two or more pieces.

- Compare the tragedies of the characters in *The Last Night* and *Refugee Blues*.
- Compare any two texts about children. How are they similar? How do they differ?
- Pick any two poems. How do they reflect the idea of a turning-point?
- How is suspense created in *A Hero*?

Writing

The topic could be suggested by a piece in the anthology, for example:

- ‘The moment had passed’ — write a short story ending with these words
- The last time I saw...
- ‘Climate change is the biggest challenge facing the world.’ What are your views on this statement?

Or an unrelated topic, for example:

- the visitor
- the person who has influenced me most
- the strangest place I have ever visited
- advice for a visitor to my area.

Assessment of written coursework

Teachers must mark each piece of coursework according to the Assessment Criteria on page 23 (Reading) and pages 25-27 (Writing) of this specification. Teachers should use their professional judgement to select and apply the criteria to the work of students appropriately and fairly. Each successive grade description assumes the continued demonstration of those qualities described in the lower grades.

Students should be awarded the appropriate mark within any range on a ‘best fit’ basis, balancing strengths and weaknesses within each essay.

Standardisation of written coursework

Towards the end of the course Edexcel will request a sample of coursework to be sent to an Edexcel-appointed coursework moderator. The moderator will either broadly confirm the marks awarded by the teachers in the centre, or will adjust marks accordingly. Where there is more than one teacher of the coursework option within a centre, the centre should conduct internal standardisation. This can be achieved by paired marking with reference to the benchmark material published by Edexcel.

Completed coursework should be kept secure within the centre until at least six months after the examination session. Coursework can then be returned to students.

Final assessment of written coursework at the end of the course

There will be two marks out of 40. These are combined to give the overall coursework mark.

- Assignment 1: Responding to the texts in Section B of the *Edexcel Anthology for International GCSE and Certificate Qualifications in English Language and Literature*.
- Assignment 2: Personal and imaginative writing (marked for Writing).

These two pieces are equally weighted. At the end of the course they may be re-assessed and the marks adjusted in light of internal standardisation.

The final overall coursework mark is a mark out of 80.

Effort and potential should not be rewarded as such. Teachers should be rewarding the quality of the writing and reading demonstrated in the essays. A second opinion by a teacher (other than the class teacher) will help the centre to arrive at an objective judgement on achievement.

Written coursework frontsheets

Final coursework marks for each student should be recorded on the coursework frontsheet — see *Appendix 2*. Teachers should photocopy the number of sheets required.

Authentication of coursework

Each student's coursework frontsheets must contain a declaration by the teacher that the work submitted for assessment is the student's own work. Attention must be drawn to the seriousness of this declaration. It is the responsibility of the centre to ensure that Edexcel's regulations are adhered to and that no student has engaged in unfair examination practice.

Teachers should be alert to essays derived from other sources — such as the internet — when signing the declaration on the coursework frontsheets.